Through the Yellow Gate

Ordination of Gender-Nonconforming People in the Buddhist Vinaya

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I dedicate this work to my parents, who have raised me to see people as people, regardless of race, nationality, sex, gender or sexuality.

Contents

1 Introduction **4**

2 Itthipaṇḍaka, Animittā, Nimittamattā, Vepurisikā **6**

3 Conclusion **8**

1 Introduction

Transgender and intersex people, and at times other LGBTIQA+ people, have been excluded from ordination as a Buddhist monastic in the *Theravāda* tradition. This exclusion is the result of what I will show is an erroneous reading of several Pali terms–*paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka*–in the monastic disciplinary code (*Vinaya Piṭaka*) of the *Theravāda* tradition. Rendering the terms *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* into English, previous lexicographers of the Pali language have used vocabulary rooted in the (Christian) understanding of the early 20th Century, like 'eunuch' and 'hermaphrodite'.[1] It has previously been noted that it is problematic to transpose modern terms in the understanding and translation of other (religious) movements.[2] In dealing with the concepts of *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* the terms 'eunuch' and 'hermaphrodite', but also terms like 'transgender' and 'intersex' are inappropriate as they wrongly suggest that the lived understanding of the relationship between sex, gender and sexuality in Ancient India was the same as it is for us in the West today. The fact that certain groups of people are unable to obtain monastic ordination based on terms that are so little understood creates a barrier for all LGBTIQA+ people who come to Buddhism seeking refuge from suffering.

When studying the Buddhist scriptures, especially where there are groups of people who are marginalized, it is important to understand where and under which circumstances these concepts and interpretations have originated.[3]

In the beginning of the Buddhist Order (*Saṅgha*) there were no rules for the conduct of monastics. The *Vinaya* was laid down later and grew as more rules were established. These were implemented only when monks started to misbehave and guidelines became necessary.[4] The *Vinaya* as we have it today was formed over a long period of time and has been highly redacted over the centuries, regulating many and diverse aspects of monastic life. It is not an original Buddhist text that was passed down unchanged since the time of the Buddha. The oldest parts of the *Vinaya* consist of the rules (*pāṭimokkha*) and procedures (*kammavācā*), possibly together with some other sections. The different *Vinayas* in existence today are the products of the various schools of Buddhism that emerged much later.[5] The Second Council is of preeminent importance in the development of the *Vinayas* as this is the only major event in Buddhist history that revolves entirely

[1] The Pali Text Society's Pali-English Dictionary and Cone's Concise Pali-English Dictionary. For dictionary entries I refer to Appendix **??**.

[2] Maes [2016a] page 2, Dudas [2002] page 45, Artinger [2020] pages 1–4.

[3] Brenna Artinger [2020] pages 3–4 points to the use of Michael Foucault's methodology of 'geneology': *"Thus, this methodology is primarily concerned with the ways in which ideas are crafted through the shaping of cultural and political influence, and one's ability to trace such lineages of formation. Through this process, one is able to see not only how or why ideas are created, but also how specific terms are negotiated through paradigms of power to bear certain connotations and interpretations."*

[4] See Bhikkhu Sujato [2009] pages 8–10 for further details on the context of the *Vinaya*.

[5] After the Buddha passed away we see a gradual emergence of schools in the Aśokan and post-Aśokan periods. See Bhikkhu Sujato [2012] for a detailed study on the emergence of the Buddhist schools.

around a *Vinaya* dispute. Bhikkhu Sujato[1] suggests that the bulk of the *Vinaya* texts were added well after the Buddha's death, in contrast to the *Suttas* (discourses):

> ... the *Vinayas* were, it seems, composed following the Second Council; and in particular the *Khandhakas*, with their massive narrative arc, were put together in order to authenticate the acts of the Second Council.

This is important for our current topic because the rules regarding the exclusion from ordination of the *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* are found in the *Khandhakas* and the words do not appear in the early *Suttas*, nor in the oldest parts of the *Vinaya*. The question remains as to why these rules were added. The Buddhist community also evolved in constant negotiation with its wider religious environment and needs to be understood as a dialogue with its various 'religious others'. Claire Maes[2] has clearly demonstrated that this process was central to the formation of the *Vinaya* as an ongoing dynamic to create a distinctive Buddhist identity. The Second Buddhist Council became an important event in the history of Buddhism to determine its identity vis-à-vis other religious Orders after the Buddha passed away.

Many scholars have pointed out the many similarities between the principal practices, precepts and structures of Buddhists, Jains and Brahman communities and they seem to have had a detailed knowledge of each other's practices and organization.[3] The interaction and debates with these 'religious others' led the Buddhist *Saṅgha* to implement specific rules in order to be in conformity with certain well-established monastic customs on the one hand and to (re)define their identity as a clearly separate Order on the other. In this paper I will argue that the concepts *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* have entered the Buddhist *Vinaya* after the Buddha passed away in the context of a much wider religious discussion that took place regarding the position of women within religious life that has also reduced the opportunities for women to ordain as Buddhist monastics.[4]

I will also show that these terms have their roots in Vedic mythology and provide a fresh insight into the ancient Asian paradigms for gender identities. Here we find the living proof of evolving ideas on sex, sexuality and gender that are very different from our Western concepts. And here we find that these terms are intimately bound up with the deeply ambivalent attitude towards women and women's sexuality in ancient India.

In this paper I will first trace the emergence of these–and other gender-specific–terms in Vedic, Brahmanic and Jain scriptures and their changes over the centuries. I will

[1] Sujato [2009] pages 141–142 and 215–216.

[2] Maes [2016a] and Maes [2016b].

[3] Maes [2016b] page 9 footnotes 26–28.

[4] The legality of the ordination of women (*Bhikkhunīs*) in the *Theravāda* and Tibetan lineages of Buddhism has been a hotly debated topic for many years. Thanks to the efforts and research of many monastics and academics, the first full *Theravāda* ordination was held in Perth in October 2009. Although still not widely recognized in several traditional *Theravāda* countries, recognition is growing and the number of *Bhikkhunīs* is slowly increasing. See a.o. Bhikkhu Sujato [2009] and Bhikkhu Anālayo [2013] for research in this field.

then discuss the occurrences of these terms in the Pali and Chinese *Vinayas* and compare these with the understanding of the contemporary 'religious others' to come to a deeper understanding of what the terms *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* really meant at the time these passages were written and the reasons why these are said to be barred from ordination. Finally I will show that neither these terms, nor any other regulations in the *Vinaya*, can be used as a justification to exclude candidates from ordination based on their sex, sexuality or gender.

2 Itthipaṇḍaka, Animittā, Nimittamattā, Vepurisikā

There are various other words mentioned in the ordination procedures for *Bhikkhunīs* as described in the *Theravāda Bhikkhunikkhandhaka* that are interesting in this context. The last three of these do not exclude an aspirant from ordination:[1]

itthipaṇḍaka	female *paṇḍaka*
animittā	woman who lacks genitals
nimittamattā	woman with incomplete genitals
vepurisikā	woman who is manlike

The word *animittā* literally means 'signless' and appears a number of times in the Canon but mostly with a different meaning, namely as in *animitto (ceto)samādhi*, which is translated by Bhikkhu Sujato as 'signless immersion', a term used in the context of meditation. In the context of not having genitals, it only appears in the Canon in the *Bhikkhunikkhandhaka* and as a form of abuse for women in the *Bhikkhu Saṁghādisesa* 3; never on its own but always in the same sequence of words of which the above are a few.

The words *nimittamattā* and *vepurisikā* are explained in the *Samantapāsādikā*:[2]

> *Nimittamattāsīti tava itthinimittaṁ aparipuṇṇaṁ saññāmattamevāti vuttaṁ hoti.*
>
> *...*
>
> *Vepurisikāti samassudāṭhikā purisarūpā itthī.*
>
> You are a *nimittamattā*: you have incomplete female characteristics (*nimitta*), merely a token.
>
> ...
>
> *Vepurisikā* means a woman who has a beard and a mustache like a man.

Table **??** gives an overview of the terms.

The first three of the above mentioned terms in the *Theravāda Bhikkhunikkhandhaka* are rather vague in their descriptions. The Chinese texts are not very clear on this point

[1] *Khandhaka* 20 *Bhikkhunikkhandhaka* PTS vol 2 page 271, translated by Ajahn Brahmali.
[2] Sp.1.285, translations by Ajahn Brahmali.

either but the overall questions asked here seem to be mostly to do with menstruation and diseases. At first glance it seems that the rules regarding ordination are trying to make sure that the girl in question is old enough for ordination and not ill. Rules concerning whether or not a girl has breasts can be explained as a question with regards to age, or it can be explained as a question to find out if she has developed the secondary characteristics needed or is possibly intersex. We will never know the true purpose behind these questions but it is not unlikely that these questions about the development of sexual organs were asked for the sole purpose of establishing age. After all, we also find rules in the *Bhikkhunīpātimokkha* that prohibit the ordination of married girls under the age of 12.[1]

The question about whether a girl is sterile would point to her at least having had one child (how else would they know if she is able to conceive?) but this would seem strange if she wants to enter a celibate Order. It seems likely that the question was intended to establish if she is at least old enough to menstruate. Another possible explanation could be that women who could not conceive would be unable to marry or would be subject to divorce if the marriage remained barren. These women might have been considered outcastes and in order to survive and for protection might have sought refuge in the *Saṅgha*. The *Saṅgha* might have therefore established these rules in order to prevent them getting inundated with candidates seeking ordination for the wrong reasons.[2] There are several stories about nuns who sought refuge in the Buddhist or Jain *Saṅghas* after having been rejected by their husbands or being widowed. We find some of these stories in the *Therīgāthā*, the Verses of the Senior Nuns, for instance in the story of *Isidāsī*,[3] *Candā*,[4] and *Paṭācārā*,[5] or in the Jain scriptures in the story of Bhadda Kundalakesa.[6]

These terms hardly appear in any texts or commentaries. Bhikkhu Sujato [2009] argues that the *Bhikkhunikkhandhaka*, as well as other parts of the *Vinaya*, are a later addition, possibly dating back to the Second Council and the elusiveness of these terms seems to confirm that. He points out that the *Bhikkhunī Vinaya* uses its own language and terminology that is often more in line with the Jain terminology and is poorly integrated with the *Bhikkhu Vinaya*.[7] This could explain the discrepancies we see between the *Bhikkhu* and *Bhikkhunī Vinayas* in describing certain words pertaining to sex/gender as used in the ordination procedures. In any case, the variability and vagueness of these terms with reference to sex/gender do not permit a clear picture.

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[1] *Pācittiya* 65 *Yā pana bhikkhunī ūnadvādasavassaṁ gihigataṁ vuṭṭhāpeyya, pācittiyaṁ.* ("Should any *Bhikkhunī* give acceptance to a married woman less than twelve years old, it is to be confessed.", translation by Thanissaro Bhikkhu)

[2] With sincere gratitude to Ajahn Brahmali for this suggestion.

[3] Thig 15.1.

[4] Thig 5.12.

[5] Hecker [1976].

[6] Hecker [1976].

[7] Sujato [2009] pages 143–145.

It is certain though that the terms *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* pertained exclusively to male candidates as we have also seen in the Jain Order while the *Bhikkhunīs* seem to have had their own vocabulary.

There are some rare cases of people who were raised from birth as girls that later became assigned as *hijra* after they failed to develop secondary female sexual characteristics (breast development and menstruation) at puberty.[1] Although there is very little evidence to go on, I believe that these cases could possibly be representing the *itthipaṇḍaka*. The term *itthipaṇḍaka* only appears in the Pali scriptures and in the *Mūlasarvāstivāda Vinaya* (黃門女). The latter defines the *itthipaṇḍaka* as either not menstruating or not having a fully formed urinal tract.[2] The Mahīśāsaka *Vinaya* talks about a 黃門 (*paṇḍaka*) without adding the character for 'female' (女). We also see a similar idea emerging in Tantric Hinduisim[3] where a woman without menstruation is seen as a 'female eunuch'.

At least for *Bhikkhunī* ordination in the *Theravāda* lineage, the characteristics of an *animittā, nimittamattā or vepurisikā* do not invalidate an ordination. This is possibly also true in several of the Chinese *Vinayas*.

3 Conclusion

I started my analysis by pointing out that a translation of the terms *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* based on a modern understanding of concepts is problematic and has led to the exclusion of transgender and intersex people from ordination.

Not only is the meaning of these terms not well understood, they have most likely been included in the *Vinaya* during the Second Council after the Buddha's death as the result of a wider religious debate with regards to the position of women in the Buddhist and Jain Orders. This hinged on the identification of the signs to designate somebody as a female, which logically also led to the examination of what is male, and 'neither male nor female'.

In this paper I have shown that the terms *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* are very likely to have deep roots in Vedic mythology and the religious enactment of that mythology by real people in sects and rituals, often involving sexual practices. The people involved in these practices were perceived as 'not male' due to a combination of physical sex-characteristics and gender-expressions and were attributed with a hyperlibidinous nature due to the role they had to play in society.

Over thousands of years people in different parts of the Buddhist world have been trying to find explanations and interpretations of these words based on their own culture and society. However very little research has been done as to the actual meaning of these

[1] Nanda [1999] page 15.

[2] T24 1451 根本說一切有部毘奈耶雜事 0364b16 and 0364b27. With much gratitude to Dr. Hsiao-Lan Hu for pointing this out.

[3] Nanda [1999] pages 21–22.

words at the time of the Buddha and shortly thereafter as well as the influence of other Orders like the Jains. We saw that the Chinese scribes, who translated the *Vinaya*, could only make sense of these words using a concept they knew in that culture, namely their own imperial palace eunuchs from the Han Dynasty, a concept which is vastly different from what the term *paṇḍaka* is trying to convey. It would equally be a mistake for us to try and interpret these words in terms of 'transgender' or 'intersex', terms we are familiar with in our Western culture. The *paṇḍaka* and *ubhatobyañjanaka* belong in a time and place where the fabric of reality and mythology were woven into each other in a way that is daunting for our Western rational minds. For thousands of years various authors have attempted to solve the inherent ambiguities in these terms, in commentarial texts and sub-commentaries, up to the present day. The truth is that the full meaning of these terms cannot be captured in single words or phrases based on modern concepts and any interpretation of these terms will always be flawed.

The only thing we can say for certain is that the *paṇḍaka* and the *ubhatobyañjanaka* are seen as problematic as candidates for ordination because they are unable to keep their precept of celibacy. This is also confirmed by the Chinese commentaries[1] as well as indicated in the origin stories. The idea that they are a threat to celibate monks because the monks might be attracted to them is not supported by the Buddhist origin stories, but could possibly be inferred from the mythological stories where shape-shifting gods seduce celibate yogis.

The main, and only, undisputed criterion for not allowing ordination to certain individuals is their difficulty in keeping the precepts. This is a fair reason for barring somebody from ordination. All criteria based on perceived or imagined sex/gender characteristics that might or might not be part of a *paṇḍaka* or *ubhatobyañjanaka* are not fair reasons. Transgender and intersex people are generally not hyperlibidinous and are just as able to keep the precepts as anyone else. It is therefore unfair, even cruel, to deny ordination to otherwise eligible individuals on the basis of a very limited and a most likely erroneous understanding of these terms, even more so because we know with a fair amount of certainty that they were inserted into the *Vinaya* after the Buddha's passing away, most likely influenced by discussions with other religious traditions which were held in a male patriarchal system where the fear of the feminine, and thus everything that is seen as 'not-male' is paramount. The wholesome aspiration to ordain and practice in line with the Dhamma is something that needs to be encouraged, not disparaged. Ordination as a monastic is not a right to be acquired to become part of an elite group through an initiation ritual. It is to be welcomed if someone feels inspired to play a part in the propagation of the Dhamma and to help safeguard it for future generations.

I certainly do not wish to justify ignoring any of the rules in the *Vinaya*. But this is an instance where contemporary social conventions are simply not covered by any of the

[1] T85 2792 毘尼心 0667b25–0667c05.

Vinaya rules. We never before had the medical knowledge about intersex or the ability to change sex with Hormone Replacement Therapy and surgery. In such a case we must not question how to make the *Vinaya* rules apply to the convention, but whether such rules apply at all. When the application of such a rule causes unnecessary suffering on the basis of very feeble arguments, I think it is unjust to do this. Regardless of how the *Vinaya* is interpreted, the doctrine of *anattā* (non-self), which is fundamental to all Buddhist schools, denies that there is an identity or lasting entity at the center of any being. So this makes sex and gender differences at the deepest level a superficial factor just like race, ethnicity, appearance or social status. Therefore to deny anybody ordination on the basis of this is in itself against the Dhamma.

In speaking with Buddhist monastics the question often arises as to which *Saṅgha*, *Bhikkhus* or *Bhikkhunīs*, a transgender or intersex person should ordain into and as such also according to which ordination procedure. This question emerges from the distinct binary structure of the Buddhist institution that reflects a society vastly different from our Western one. This might have been appropriate at the time of the Buddha, but it is not necessarily appropriate for our current time and place and we will have to rethink how we deal with these issues. I therefore think we should leave such questions to the individuals involved based on their gender-experience in consultation with the members of the community they wish to ordain into. The *Vinaya* has given us an example where the person could simply live in the *Saṅgha* according to their own gender-experience[1] where they could practice in a way that was most appropriate to them in order to get the best possible opportunities to eradicate defilements and practice the teachings. As I have outlined in this article, in ancient India there was a lively debate with regards to the characteristics that make up a 'man' or a 'woman' and these are not so clear-cut and also not limited to primary sex characteristics. There are however many variables involved and in which community a person would benefit most is not a question that is easy to answer and should be carefully considered on a case-by-case basis.

The preservation of the religious institution and its public image is an important reason for the establishment of the *Vinaya*.[2] As Buddhism has spread across the world and across many socio-cultural environments, the challenge for the institution is to maintain its integrity while at the same time acknowledge the socio-cultural differences in the environments it operates in, the people who support it and to whom it aims to provide a refuge from suffering. Unfortunately we see all too often that people in Western cultures, already disillusioned with religion due to the scandals, misogyny and sexism in the Catholic Church, turn away from Buddhism and the Dhamma because they are unable to reconcile the inclusive nature of the teachings with yet another rigid patriarchal institution that seems out of place in the modern Western world. If we are not careful in

[1] PTS vol. 3 page 35. See also chapter **??**.

[2] Brenna Artinger [2020] cites Shayne Clarke, page 66.

addressing these issues we may end up damaging the reputation of the *Saṅgha*, which we aimed to preserve.

Article 1 of the UN Universal Declaration of Human Rights reads: "All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights". Denying ordination on the basis of sex or gender is against basic human rights and as Buddhists it is not only our duty to ensure the ethical standards that are expected of us in our society, but also to be the living examples of the Buddha's compassion for all beings.

> As Buddhists who espouse the ideal of unconditional loving kindness and respect, judging people on their behavior instead of their birth, we should be well positioned to show leadership on the development of gender equality in the modern world and the consequent reduction of suffering for half the world's population. Moreover, if Buddhism is to remain relevant and grow, we must address these issues head on. But how can we speak about gender equality when some of our own *Theravāda* Buddhist organizations are gender biased? *Ajahn Brahmavaṁso*

Table 1: Antarāyika dhammas

	Theravāda	Mahīśāsaka	Dharmaguptaka	Sarvāstivāda	Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda		Mūlasarvāstivāda		
	Cullavagga X, Khandhaka 20	T1421	T 1428	T 1435	T 1425	Bhikṣuṇī-vinaya (Roth)	T1453	D0006	BhīKaVā (Schmidt)
	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
on genitals									
Do you lack genitals?	1 (nasi animittā)						14 (無道)	19 (mtshan med pa)	17 (mā avyañjanā)
Are your genitals incomplete?	2 (nasi nimittamattā)	8 (女根具足不)		9 (非偏不)			13 (汝非小道)	24 (mtshan ma tsam yod pa)	22 (mā naimittikī)
Are your genitals too small?			11 (道小)	11 (女根不小不)					
Do you have genital prolapse?	7 (nasi sikharaṇī)				25 (非爛墮不)	21 (mā śikhiriṇī)			
Do you have (vaginal) fistula?	10 (nasi sambhinnā)	11 (非二道合不)	10 (二道合)	10 (不二道合不)	26 (非二道通不)		15 (二道合)	21 (gle 'dams pa)	19 (mā saṃbhinnavyañjanā)
Do you have genital hair?				6 (女根上有毛不)					
are your genitals withered or decayed?				7 (不枯壞不)	27 (非破不)				
on menstruation									
Do you menstruate?	3 (nasi alohitā)	12 (月水出不)		16 (非無月忌不)	31 (非無血不)		17 (無血不)	23 (khrag med pa)	21 (mā alohinī)
Do you menstruate continuously?	4 (nasi dhuvalohitā)	13 (不常出不)		15 (非恒有月水不)	30 (非常血病不)		16 (汝非身常流血不)	22 (rtag tu khrag 'dzag pa)	20 (mā sadāprasrutalohinī)
Do you always wear a menstruation pad?	5 (nasi dhuvacoḷā)				32 (非一月常血不)				

	Theravāda	Mahīśāsaka	Dharmaguptaka	Sarvāstivāda	Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda		Mūlasarvāstivāda		
	Cullavagga X, Khandhaka 20	T1421	T 1428	T 1435	T 1425	Bhikṣuṇī-vinaya (Roth)	T1453	D0006	BhīKaVā (Schmidt)
	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Do you have vaginal discharge?				8 (無癰下病不)					
Are you incontinent?	6 (nasi paggharantī)	(漏病 in list of diseases)	12 (大小便常漏)		(不禁 in list of diseases)		(下漏 in list of diseases)		
on third gender									
Are you an itthipaṇḍakā?	8 (nasi itthipaṇḍakā)	9 (汝非黃門不)				23 (mā stripaṇḍikā)	18 (汝非黃門不)		
Are you manlike?	9 (nasi vepurisikā)					22 (mā dvipuruṣikā)			
Are you a ubhatobyañjanā?	11 (nasi ubhatobyañjanā)		9 (二根)					20 (mtshan gnyis pa)	18 (mā ubhayavyañjanā)
on reproduction									
Are you pregnant?								18 (sbrum ma)	16 (mā gurviṇī)
Are you a barren woman?		10 (非石女不)			24 (非石女不)				
Are you incapable (of sexual intercourse)?				5 (非是不能女不)					
Are you impotent?				12 (非是不能產不)	33 (非不能女不)				
Do you lack milk (or breasts)?				13 (非是無乳不)	28 (不無乳不)				
Do you have just one breast?				14 (非是一乳不)	29 (非一乳不)				

	Theravāda	Mahīśāsaka	Dharmaguptaka	Sarvāstivāda	Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda		Mūlasarvāstivāda		
	Cullavagga X, Khandhaka 20	T1421	T 1428	T 1435	T 1425	Bhikṣuṇī-vinaya (Roth)	T1453	D0006	BhīKaVā (Schmidt)
	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
on mental state									
Are you vicious?								16 (mi srun pa)	14 (mā caṇḍā)
Are you overcome with grief?							12 (汝非憂愁損心不)	17 (mya ngan gyis gdungs pa)	15 (mā śokahatā)
Are you a man-hater?						24 (mā puruṣadveṣiṇī)			
on being human									
Are you human?	12 (manussāsi)	6 (是人不)		2 (是人不)					
Are you a non-human?				3 (非是非人不)					
Are you a woman?	13 (itthīsi)	7 (是女人不)	8 (是女人不)	1 (汝是女不)	23 (汝是女不)		1 (汝是女人不)	1 (bud med)	1 (strī tvaṃ)
You are a magical apparition?				4 (非畜生不)			31 (非化人不)	11 (sprul pa)	10 (mā vaktavyikā)
on social status									
Are you a slave?	14 (bhujissāsi)	5 (非婢不)	7 (非婢不)	17 (非婢不)	18 (汝非婢不)	15 (mā dāsi)	7 (汝非婢不)	6 (bran mo)	6 (māsi dāsī)
Have you been abducted?				20 (非破得不)	19 (非養女不)			7 (phrogs)	7 (na hi mā āhṛtikā)
Have you been sold?				19 (非買得不)	19 (非養女不)			9 (btsongs pa)	8 (mā vikrītikā)
Are you a pawn?								8 (rnyed pa)	
Have you offered yourself as a servant in lieu of payment of a loan?				18 (非客作不)					9 (mā vaktavyikā)

	Theravāda	Mahīśāsaka	Dharmaguptaka	Sarvāstivāda	Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda		Mūlasarvāstivāda		
	Cullavagga X, Khandhaka 20	T1421	T 1428	T 1435	T 1425	Bhikṣuṇī-vinaya (Roth)	T1453	D0006	BhīKaVā (Schmidt)
	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Are you desired by anyone?								10 (chags pa)	
Are you free from debt?	15 (aṇaṇāsi)	1 (不負債不)	6 (不負人債不)	24 (不負他物不)	20 (不負人債不)	17 (mā ṛṇahārikā)	32 (汝非負債不)	44 (gzhan gyi lon mang yang rung nyung yang rung chags pa)	42 (mā tvayā kasya cit kiñ cid deyaṃ alpaṃ vā prabhūtaṃ vā)
Are you employed by the king?	16 (nasi rājabhaṭī)	4 (不屬官不)		22 (非吏婦不)	21 (非兵婦不)	18 (mā rājabhaṭi)	8 (汝非宮人不) + 9 (國主聽汝不)	12 (rgyal po la gtses pa)	11 (mā rājabhaṭī)
Are you the wife of a soldier?		2 (非他婦不)		21 (非兵婦不)					
Do you bear a grudge against the king?								13 (rgyal po dang 'khon pa)	12 (mā rājakilviṣiṇī)
Have you acted to harm the king (or instigated others to do so)?				23 (非犯官事不)	22 (非陰謀王家不)	19 (mā rājñaḥ kilbiṣakāriṇi)	10 (汝非王家毒害人不)	14-15 (rgyal po la gnod pa'i las byas sam/ pa'am byed du bcug pa)	13 (mā tvayā rājāpathyaṃ karma kṛtaṃ vā kāritaṃ vā)
on permission									
Are your father and mother and your husband alive?					1 (父母夫主在不)		4 (汝父母在不)	4 (pha ma dang khyim thab (rnams) gson pa)	4 (jīvatas te mātāpitarau svāmī vā jīvati)
Do you have permission from your parents and husband?	17 (anuññātāsi mātāpitūhi, sāmikena)	3 (夫主聽不) + 16 (父母聽不)	5 (父母若夫主為聽汝不)		2 (父母夫主聽不)	1 (anujñātāsi anujñāpakehi)	5 (聽汝出家不) + 6 (汝夫主在不)	5 (pha dang ma dang khyo rnams/ khyim thab kyis gnang pa)	5 (anujñātāsi mātāpitṛbhyāṃ svāminā vā)
Are you twenty years old? (or in case of a married woman living in a household twelve years?)	18 (paripuṇṇavīsati-vassāsi)		3 (年滿二十不)				2 (汝年滿二十未？若曾嫁女者問：汝年滿十四未？)	2 (khyim du/na gnas pa lo bcu gnyis pa'am | gzhon nu ma lo nyi shu tshang pa)	2 (strī gṛhoṣitā dvādaśavarṣā kumārikā vā paripūrṇaviṃśativarṣā)

	Theravāda	Mahīśāsaka	Dharmaguptaka	Sarvāstivāda	Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda		Mūlasarvāstivāda		
	Cullavagga X, Khandhaka 20	T1421	T 1428	T 1435	T 1425	Bhikṣuṇī-vinaya (Roth)	T1453	D0006	BhīKaVā (Schmidt)
	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Do you have a full set of bowl and robes?	19 (paripuṇṇaṁ te pattacīvaraṁ)		4 (衣鉢具不)		4 (五衣鉢具不)	3 (paripūrṇan te pātracivaraṃ)	3 (汝五衣鉢具不)	3 (chos gos lnga dang lhung bzed du ldan pa)	3 (paripūrṇaṃ te pañcacīvaraṃ pātraṃ ca)
What’s your name?	20 (kiṁnāmāsi)		1 (汝字何等)		7 (汝字何等)		34 (汝名字何)	45 (khyod kyi ming ci)	43 (kinnāmikā tvaṃ)
Has a preceptor been found?		15 (已求和尚未)			3 (求和上尼未)	2 (yācitā te upādhyāyinī)			
What’s the name of your preceptor?	21 (kānāmā te pavattinī)		2 (和尚字誰)		8 (和上尼字誰)		35 (鄔波馱耶字何)	46 (khyod kyi mkhan mo’i ming ci)	44 (kinnāmikā te upādhyāyikā)
ānantariya									
Have you killed your father?					9 (汝不殺父母不)	8 (mā pitṛghātini)	20 (汝非殺父不)	26 (pha bsad pa)	25 (mā pitṛghātikā)
Have you killed your mother?					9 (汝不殺父母不)	7 (mā mātṛghātini)	21 (汝非殺母不)	27 (ma bsad pa)	24 (mā mātṛghātikā)
Have you killed an arhat?					10 (不殺阿羅漢不)	9 (mā arhantaghātinī)	22 (汝非殺阿羅漢不)	28 (dgra bcom pa bsad pa)	26 (mā arhadghātikā)
Have you caused a schism in the Sangha?					11 (不破僧不)	10 (mā saṃghabhedikā)	23 (汝非破和合僧伽不)		
Have you shed the blood of a tathāgata with malicious intent?					12 (不惡心出佛身血不佛久已涅槃而故依舊文)	11 (mā tathāgatasya duṣṭacittarudhirot-pādikā)	24 (汝非惡心出佛身血不)	29 (de bzhin gshegs pa’i sku la ngan sems kyis khrag phyung ba)	27 (mā tathāgatasyāntike duṣṭacittarudhirot-pādikā)
other disqualified persons									
Have you seduced a bhikṣu?					13 (不壞比丘淨戒不)	12 (mā bhikṣudūṣikā)	19 (汝非污苾芻不)	25 (dge slong bslus pa)	23 (mā bhikṣudūṣikā)

	Theravāda	Mahīśāsaka	Dharmaguptaka	Sarvāstivāda	Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda		Mūlasarvāstivāda		
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	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Are you an adherent of a non-Buddhist sect?						13 (mā stainyasamvāsikā)	25 (汝非外道不)	30 (mu stegs can)	28 (mā tīrthikā)
Have you gone over to a non-Buddhist sect?					15 (非越濟人不)	14 (mā tirthikā-pakrāntikā)	26 (現是外道汝非趣外道不)	31 (mu stegs can du 'gro ba)	29 (mā tīrthāvakrāntikā)
Have you previously gone forth, gone over to a non-Buddhist sect and now returned again?							27 (先已出家，還歸外道，更復重來汝非賊住不)		
Are you not a notorious bandit?					14 (非賊盜住不)	16 (mā avapitikā)	11 (汝非賊不)	32 (rkun po'i rgyal mtshan can)	30 (mā caurī)
You are not one who lives by theft, are you?								33 (rkun gnas pa / rku thabs su gnas pa)	31 (mā dhvajabaddhikā / mā steyasaṃvāsikā)
Do you live apart?							28 (汝非別住不)	34 (so sor gnas pa)	32 (mā nānāsaṃvāsikā)
Are you entitled to live [with the order]?							29 (汝非不共住不)	35 (mi gnas pa)	33 (mā asaṃvāsikā)
on going forth									
Did you renounce the household life voluntarily?					16 (不自出家不)				
Have you received the full ordination previously?					17 (本曾受具足不)	20 (upasampan-napūrvāsi)	33 (汝非先出家不)	36 (sngon rab tu byung ba)	34 (kaccit tvaṃ pūrvaṃ pravrajiteti)
Have you now gone forth and practiced chastity well?							30 (先犯重人汝不)	37 (da ltar rab tu byung nas tshangs par spyod pa yang dag par spyad pa)	35 (kaccit tvayā samyag brahmacaryañ caritaṃ)

	Theravāda	Mahīśāsaka	Dharmaguptaka	Sarvāstivāda	Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda		Mūlasarvāstivāda		
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	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Have you requested the two years' training in the six dharmas and the six subordinate dharmas from the bhikṣuṇī saṃgha?								38 (dge slong ma' i dge ' dun gyis lo gnyis su chos drug dang rjes su chos drug bslab pa gsol pa (second list: byin pa))	36 (kaccit tvayā bhikṣuṇīsaṃghe dve varṣe ṣaṭsu dharmeṣu ṣaṭsv anudharmeṣu śikṣā yācitā)
Have you trained for two years in the six dharmas and the six subordinate dharmas?		14 (學二歲戒日滿不)			5 (學戒二歲滿不)	4 (deśitaśikṣāsi)		39 (lo gnyis su chos drug dang rjes su chos drug gi bslab pa bslabs pa)	37 (śikṣitā tvaṃ dve varṣe ṣaṭsu dharmeṣu ṣaṭsv anudharmeṣu śikṣāyāṃ)
Do you wish to receive the full ordination?		17 (欲受具足戒不)							
Are you perfected in the training?						5 (paripūrṇaśikṣāsi)			
Has the saṅgha of bhikṣuṇīs conferred the vow that generates the holy life?								40 (dge slong ma'i dge 'dun gyis tshangs par spyad pa skyed pa'i sdom pa phog gam)	38 (dattā te bhikṣuṇīsaṃghena brahmacaryopasthā-nasaṃvṛtir dattā)
Have the saṅgha of bhikṣuṇīs performed the preliminary formal acts?					6 (作畜眾羯磨未)			41 (dge slong ma'i dge 'dun gyis sngar bya ba'i las rnams byas pa)	39 (kṛtaṃ te bhikṣuṇīsaṃghena pūrvakālakaraṇīyaṃ kṛtaṃ)
Have you been approved by the bhikṣuṇīs and are their minds pleased?						6 (sammatāsi viśuddhāsi bhikṣuṇīhi)		42 (dge slong ma'i dge 'dun rnams kyi sems mgu bar byas pa)	40 (ārādhitaṃ te bhikṣuṇīsaṃghasya / cittam ārādhitaṃ)
Are you completely pure?						6 (sammatāsi viśuddhāsi bhikṣuṇīhi)		43 (bar chad kyi chos rnams las yongs su dag pa)	41 (pariśuddhāsi na vā)

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